

Board: 2

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 4

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board 2

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 6 5
♥ K 7
♦ 10 9 8 5
♣ K J 8 2

♠ A 4 2
♥ Q J 10 5 3
♦ K J 7
♣ A 3



♠ Q J 10 8
♥ 9 4
♦ A 6 3 2
♣ 10 9 6

♠ K 7 3
♥ A 8 6 2
♦ Q 4
♣ Q 7 5 4

West	North	East	South
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
you should try to find somewhere to put the ♠ loser.

You have 11 (perhaps 12) points and four trumps.
Just right for a limit raise.

So you bid 3♥ and partner goes to game.

South would play 4♥.

Click

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You know you can't get rid of the ♦ loser, and it's hard to imagine a way that would let you get rid of the ♣ loser. The ♥ loser depends on the finesse. So

First you win the ♠A. You know that you will eventually take the ♥ finesse, so should you take it now? Visualize the likely defense actions if you do. Say West wins the ♥K. He will surely play another ♠, knocking out dummy's ♠K. Whenever you try to set up ♦s the defense will take their ♠ trick and you will eventually go down.

What happened is that you gave the defense a tempo and let them control the timing of the play. You should not have rushed into the ♥ finesse. Instead suppose that you win the first trick with dummy's ♠K and immediately play the ♦Q. The defense can take their ♦A when they want to and push another ♠, but now the timing is on your side. You can discard a ♠ from dummy on your good ♦ in time.

Take the ♥ finesse before you set up a ♦ trick and you will be just fine if the finesse wins. But if it loses you will lose a tempo and the defense will get to your ♠ loser before you can set up a ♦.

Set up the ♦ winner before you take the ♥ finesse and you will always be able to dump the ♠ loser no matter who has the ♥K.

Board 4

East Deals

Both Vul

♠ Q 10 4
♥ A Q J 6
♦ 7 5 4
♣ K 10 8

♠ 8 6 5

♥ 9 7 3

♦ Q 10 6 3

♣ A 9 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A J 9 3

♥ K 8 2

♦ A 8

♣ Q J 5 3

♠ K 7 2

♥ 10 5 4

♦ K J 9 2

♣ 7 6 4

West	North	East	South
------	-------	------	-------

2♣

Pass

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 4 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

With 15 points and a balanced hand of course you open 1NT.

Partner's response is 2♣.

Partner's 2♣ bid is Stayman asking you to name a 4-card Major.

You bid 2♠, but that must not have been the Major he wanted so he bids 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦2. North plays ♦Q. You hold up on this trick and North returns the ♦3.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦2. North plays ♦Q. You hold up on this trick and North returns the ♦3.

You need to get three more winners and you have two very clear possibilities.

If North holds the ♠K you can finesse him out of it and win an additional 3 tricks in the suit. The problem with this approach is that half the time South will hold the ♠K and you will go down.

Or you can drive out the ♣A and definitely set up an additional 3 tricks in that suit. The problem with this approach is that if the defender's ♦s split 5-3 they will be able to win 4 ♦s and the ♣A.

If you pay attention to the opening lead this becomes a simple decision. South led the ♦2. Assuming that was fourth down then he must have led from a 4-card suit. So it looks like the ♦s must be splitting 4-4 and it is safe for you to establish ♣s. So you drive out the ♣A. The defenders take their other 2 ♦s but you make the game losing only 3 ♦s and the ♣A.

In this layout the ♠ finesse fails, as it would do half the time.

South's lead of the ♦2 should have made you pretty sure that he had led from a 4-card suit. If the ♦2 is fourth down, there cannot be a fifth down. Additionally, North's return of the ♦3 confirmed that conclusion. If North had started with only 3 ♦s, (say ♦Q 6 3) his correct return at trick 2 would have been his next highest, the ♦6. With 4 cards in the suit his correct return is his original fourth down.